

INDRA IRWAN HAS
*SOMETHING
TO SAY*

Not everyone's cup of tea.
He's spilling anyway.

Creative Strategist

Creative Group Head

Content Lead

Bilingual Writer

Brand • Digital • Culture





THE WORK BENEATH THE WORK

For Indra, it's all about the motivation under the surface.

There is little appetite, in his telling, for inflated frameworks or the theatre of intelligence that advertising sometimes mistakes for substance.

Instead, he talks about clarity, tension, and cultural signals. Those strange little moments when an audience understands something before they can explain why.

For more than fifteen years, across agencies, brands, and markets, Indra has built a career helping people say what they actually mean. Or, more precisely, helping them realise what they meant all along.

His work sits somewhere between strategy, copywriting, cultural interpretation, and creative direction. It is a space that resists neat job titles, which is probably why he has moved through several of them: senior copywriter, creative group head, digital strategist, regional content lead, freelancer, consultant.

And even as the titles change, the work underneath remains consistent.

AT A GLANCE

15+

YEARS OF TURNING
IDEAS INTO MEANING

~65%

PITCH WIN RATE

MY • SG • SEA

REGIONAL EXPERIENCE



One thing is consistent. Indra is the guy you call when something isn't landing.

A brief feels clear, but the work does not move. A brand has things to say, but none feel ownable. A campaign has a proposition, but no pulse.

"You can usually tell when a brand is solving the wrong problem," he says.

"They ask for better copy, but the real issue is that they don't know what role they want to play in people's lives."

HIS METHODS AGAINST THE CHAOS

Like that meme of an old man pretending to be a high school student, some brands try to fit into culture without really understanding it. The culture always knows. Indra believes there's a way to actually belong in the room.

The Anti-Imposter Framework

01 IMMERSE

Genuinely engage in what the culture enjoys. Understand the context and the reasoning.

Look for similar signals and study the pattern. Then step out of your algorithmic bubble.

02 DECODE

The window between "emerging" and "everyone's doing it" is shorter than most brands think. The job is to spot the pattern before it becomes a trend. Being second isn't always losing. Being late always is.

03 CLAIM

Not every trend belongs to every brand. The key is to find the cultural space closest to the brand and build a home there, rather than forcefully trespassing.



Anybody can build a framework.

Having worked across global and regional brands, Indra also shows an appreciation for discipline, cultural flexibility, speed, and nerve.

This helped him understand that advertising is both craft and compromise; both culture and commerce. He has seen enough of the industry to be clear-eyed about it and still find it worth doing.

Fifteen years is a long time. What keeps you from going through the motions?

To be honest, I'm nosy by nature. This job just makes the energy useful. I get to learn a lot about people, and that never gets boring.

What did regional work teach you that local work could not?

That consistency is not the same as sameness. Regional work teaches you to respect the centre without flattening the edges.

I also learned to consider nuance, context, and culture. So, I always check the room before I write for it.

You sound confident. When did you stop second-guessing yourself?

I've been in a lot of rooms where someone has to say, "That idea's not good enough." Lately, that person has been me.

When people ask for my opinion, trust it, and act on it, I realise what I'm good at is knowing what's missing and how to bridge the gap.

If you could fix one thing about how brands talk to people, what would it be?

They think the problem is expression, when it is often identity.

Comms can't invent something the brand is not willing to be or offer.

So, what are clients or agencies really getting when they hire you?

Discernment. A unique point of view. I grew up in the city, but in a *kampung*-like environment. That kept me in the loop yet helped me avoid cultural blind spots.

If your work has a signature, what is it?

Clarity with a little friction. It has to be sharp, but not sterile. Emotional, but not indulgent. I have a soft spot for wordplay, and I won't apologise for it.

My signature, if there's one: clarity with heart...a little cheek if I can get away with it. You see it in my work.



When RM30,000 Became RM130,000

THE BRIEF

To develop a national pride film for MILO for Hari Kebangsaan and Hari Malaysia. The budget? RM30,000.

THE REAL OPPORTUNITY

MILO has been present in Malaysians' lives since before independence. That is a truth worth building around.

THE IDEA

A film that traces MILO's role as a brand that has always been there as we celebrate Malaysia's milestones. From the family's breakfast table to the mamak stalls, it helps bring the cheers.

WHAT IT TOOK

Convincing the client that the story was worth more than the original budget. The budget grew from RM30,000 to RM130,000, and we even secured Fauziah Nawî, one of Malaysia's most beloved actresses, as the voiceover talent.

WHAT IT BECAME

A heartfelt piece that resonated with millions. It became proof that a constrained brief, when given the right idea, can turn into an invitation.



From No Brief to A Lifeline

THE BRIEF

A Merdeka campaign for foodpanda with no specific direction given.

THE REAL OPPORTUNITY

Malaysia was in lockdown. Businesses were failing, and ordinary people were hanging white flags outside their homes as a signal for help. The real brief: what was already happening on the ground.

THE IDEA

Turn foodpanda's existing network into a relief movement. Vendors on the app pledged support with food and daily necessities while riders were mobilised to respond whenever they spotted a white flag.

WHAT IT TOOK

Coordinating between the Bangkok regional HQ, the KL office, vendors, and riders across Malaysia during a lockdown.

WHAT IT BECAME

A campaign documented through UGC from the people who lived it. More importantly, it became a network activated to do something real, for the right reason.



The One-Week Brief That Got 6M Views

THE BRIEF

To create a “viral” Hari Raya video for SJPP, with only one week to present ideas.

THE REAL OPPORTUNITY

The client wanted to go with either an emotional or humour route to ensure virality. But the direction needed to be human first.

THE IDEA

We wrapped the idea around phenomena — businesses popping up only during Ramadan, the matcha strawberry trend, operating food trucks — but kept the core on relationships, hope, and celebration.

WHAT IT TOOK

One week of conceptualising ideas, filming during Ramadan and working against a very tight deadline. The film was also supported by a social and influencer plan to ensure it spread.

WHAT IT BECAME

Despite the crowded festive season, the video reached six million views and achieved relevance in a moment already saturated with Raya content.



FIELD NOTES

Not every piece of Indra's work becomes a case study.

"If they did, I would've sold courses and become a millionaire," he says casually.

But every brief leaves a trace; a way of turning an ask into something with a point.



“
*The work doesn't always
need the same version of
me. That's probably why
I've survived this long.*

”

Note #01

Harus Ada Aruz — Perodua
Tech / Social

The client wanted testimonials. Instead, we turned real drivers' stories into AI-assisted songs, performed by popular singer Syamel.

They became memorable bops.

Note #02

**#jomkreatifplaytime —
Dutch Lady**
Social / Strategy

What began as a social campaign grew into a multi-phase initiative: an influencer-led social stunt, activations, and an on-ground event that made parents pause to play with their kids.

Note #03

Pitch — Pizza Hut
Strategy /
Creative Direction

We had a workable brand platform — turning Pizza Hut into a third space. To make it relevant, we turned it into a youth-inspired invitation with real cultural pulse. [REDACTED FOR NDA] — Ask me about it.



A CAREER IN YEARS

Different titles.
Agencies.
In-house.
Independent.
One through-line.

“

*This is what 15
years looks like
when you
follow the work,
not the ladder.*

”

● 2023 -
Present

The Independent Years

Freelance Creative Strategist
& Writer
(Various Clients & Agencies)

Leaner than an agency. The same full experience. Strategy, copy, pitches, and creative direction for clients who need the point sharpened.

● 2020 -
2022

The Early Strategist Years

Regional Content Lead (*foodpanda*)
Digital Strategist & Sr Writer
(Hakuhodo)

Moved deeper into systems: brand voice, content coherence, regional alignment, and managing up, across, and sideways.

● 2017 -
2020

The Creative Leadership Years

Creative Grp. Head (*Reprise Digital*)
Regional Sr Copywriter (*Grab SEA*)

Led teams, won pitches, shaped campaigns, and learned how one message travels across many markets.

● 2012 -
2017

The Craft Years

Sr Copywriter (TBWA\ Media Arts Lab)
Copywriter (TBWA\ Kuala Lumpur)

Built the discipline of big ideas, careful language, global standards, and local resonance.

● 2010 -
2012

The Starting Years

Social Media Writer (*DraftFCB KL*)
Copywriter (*Creative Juice-Sil KL*)

Started without a traditional portfolio. Learned fast through copy, content, community, reporting, and the early chaos of social.





ICONOGRAPHY

Some ideas are buried in the deck graveyard.

Some flourish because somewhere along the way, a client, a team, or a brand had enough patience, nerve, and vision to say yes.

These are those that made room for the ideas, not just gave Indra a brief. They gave the ideas a fighting chance.



And this is not an exhaustive list.

The selected brands featured represent clients Indra has worked with over his career. Indra did the work. They did everything else. Inclusion does not imply current affiliation or endorsement. All trademarks belong to their respective owners.



Is Indra for You?

Others have worked with him. Check if he is what you need.

What He Writes

- ☐ Copywriting (English & BM)
- ☐ Bilingual Adaptation & Transcreation

What He Thinks

- ☐ Brand Strategy & Positioning
- ☐ Creative Direction
- ☐ Campaign Ideation & Development
- ☐ Pitch Development & Presentation

**One tick is enough
to start a conversation.**

What He Builds

- ☐ Content Strategy & Systems
- ☐ Digital & Social Strategy
- ☐ Short-form Video Strategy
- ☐ Social Analytics & Reporting
- ☐ AI-Integrated Creative Workflow

What He Leads

- ☐ Influencer & Creator Strategy
- ☐ Employer Branding & Internal Comms
- ☐ Regional & Cross-Market Work
- ☐ Workshop Facilitation
& Creative Consulting

WHILE YOU'RE HERE

OUTSIDE THE BRIEF

Things to do when you're not thinking about brands.



READ

Indra's "*Notes for Revision*" on Substack. You'll get (mild) agency critique and how we can do better.



LISTEN

to *Manifest with Indra* on Spotify. An audio guide for the things you actually want, minus the hustle culture.



THINK ABOUT

the blog on indrairwan.com. Connect the dots between global events and modern structures that shape society.





OPEN FOR A CONVERSATION

Over fifteen years of having something to say.
So what's next? Whatever it is, it has to matter.

If the work needs more meaning,
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podcast, and more.

